130 Million Shattered Lives

By Tanya (a refugee), Wang Ping Blas Manuel DeLuna and Denice Frohman

Solidarity by Tanya

Women clothed in their leader's regalia

Men, adorned in T-shirts with the leader's face on their broad chests.

The volume of their voices singing songs

Praise, adoration, appreciation and dedication could be heard miles away.

Milk and honey, they sang.

No matter how badly the weeds had grown in the fields,

People dropped everything to be there,

To attend the rally and listen first-hand.

They glided,

Some carried cockerels, goats, baskets full of eggs,

Or vegetables to give to the heroes who had fought and brought us freedom.

We loved them, our heroes.

Nobody wanted anyone to cough or whisper,

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Nobody wanted to miss a single word.

We worshipped them like gods.

Worshipping the ground they walked on.

We became very close,

Following everywhere they went, to show our solidarity.

Then things began to change.

INTRODUCTION

*****130 million – That's the number of people the UN Refugee Agency expects to be forcibly displaced or stateless by the end of 2024. – 130 million.

It's difficult to find the right words to describe the plight faced by this staggering number of refugees. Being (insert age) from (insert hometown) I can only imagine the confusion, fear, and the overwhelming sense of hopelessness. For those outside the crises, these people have become statistics -- repetitive news reports -- and I worry that we have become immune to their humanity.

I don't have the words, but many immigrant writers have brought their experiences to life through journals, letters and poetry. Their truth transcends location. **I** don't have the words, so I'll give voice to theirs.

130 Million Shattered Lives with poems by a refugee known only as Tanya, Wang Ping, Blas Manuel De Luna and Denice Frohman.

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Solidarity by Tanya (con't)

It came to me in an instance.

I had bought a new cup from a second-hand shop

When I lifted it up to the sunlight, I couldn't see any flaws.

When I got home, I decided to christen it with a cup of tea.

But the moment I poured the boiling water, it cracked down the middle.

It came to me in an instance: what was happening in our country.

Everything looked perfect, all the words they said,

But something was very wrong.

Meetings held in secret,

People began to attend less and less.

Chiefs were threatened:

Villagers needed to attend, or food aid would be withdrawn.

The threats became more frequent

And then the militia used their force.

Gates were shut, and militia manned them:

People could come in, but no one could leave

Even if you had medical problems.

Then came the public flogging

Of those who had deserted.

Brutal! It was brutal.

All our hopes, dreams shattered.

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All we wanted was to have our voices heard.

To build the country as one.

But all was denied.

We had been in solidarity with them for a long time.

Now they were stabbing us and maiming all those who dared to oppose.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tanya (a refugee)
On-Line Transcript:
https://www.freedomfromtorture.org/real-voices/six-refugee-poems-insight-life-refugees-and-asylum-seekers
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Freedom From Torture.org
Date (Month/Year): Accessed on July 3, 2024

things we carry on the sea by Wang Ping (Pg 7)

we carry tears in our eyes: good-bye father, good-bye mother

we carry soil in small bags: may home never fade in our hearts

we carry names, stories, memories of our village, our civilization

we carry scars from proxy wars of greed

we carry carnage of mining, droughts, floods, genocides

we carry dust of our families incinerated in mushroom clouds

we carry our islands sinking under the sea

we carry our hands, feet, bones, hearts and best minds to start a new life

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we carry diplomas: medicine, engineer, nurse, education, math,

poetry, even if they mean nothing to the other shore

we carry railroads, plantations, laundromats, bodegas, taco

trucks, farms, factories, nursing homes, hospitals, schools,

temples. . . built on our ancestors' backs

we carry old homes along the spine, new dreams in our chests

we carry yesterday, today and tomorrow

we're orphans of the wars forced upon us

we're refugees of the sea drowning in plastic wastes

we came from the same mother in Africa

we're your children, sisters and brothers, father and mother

our tongues carry the same weight as we chant

爱(ai), حب (hubb), ליבע (libe), amor, ***love***

平安 (ping'an), سلام (salaam), shalom, paz, ***peace***

希望 (xi'wang), أمل ('amal), hofenung, esperanza, ***hope***, ***hope,***

hope

as we drift . . . from dream to dream . . . sea to sea . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Wang Ping
Book: My Name is Immigrant, Pg 7
ISBN: 978-1934909669
Publisher: Hanging Loose Press
Date (Month/Year): May 2020

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TRANSITION

For those refugees fortunate enough to reach the US border, you would think that their troubles are finally over --- "Give us your tired, your poor, your huddled masses yearning to breathe free . . ." Unfortunately, some borders are more than physical and cannot be crossed only by foot.

Currently those arriving in the US seeking asylum protection are facing extended waiting periods – up to 7 years in some cases. Meanwhile, they have restrictions on their right to work and to assistance programs, making it nearly impossible for them to support themselves or their families.

Bent to the Earth by Blas Manuel De Luna

They had hit Ruben

with the high beams, had blinded

him so that the van

he was driving, full of Mexicans

going to pick tomatoes,

would have to stop. Ruben spun

the van into an irrigation ditch,

spun the five-year-old me awake

to immigration officers,

their batons already out,

already looking for the soft spots on the body,

to my mother being handcuffed

and dragged to a van, to my father
trying to show them our green cards.

They let us go. But Alvaro
was going back.
So was his brother Fernando.
So was their sister Sonia. Their mother
did not escape,
and so was going back. Their father
was somewhere in the field,
and was free. There were no great truths

revealed to me then. No wisdom
given to me by anyone. I was a child
who had seen what a piece of polished wood
could do to a face, who had seen his father
about to lose the one he loved, who had lost
some friends who would never return,
who, later that morning, bent
to the earth and went to work.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Blas Manuel De Luna
Book: Bent to the Earth
ISBN: 978-0887484315
Publisher: Carnegie Mellon University
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2005

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AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier – MS – This poem only

Borders by Denice Frohman (Pg 86-89)

It starts before she gets here.
before the stairs tell her she is alien
to a country that knows her great
grandfather's Mexican hands all too well.
His fingerprints still echo underneath
the railroad tracks and cotton fields
where bent knees and bent backs
once picked, plucked, pushed work
for more money than he was used to,
but less than he deserved.

For Ana Maria, it begins before the border.
She walks with her two Uncles and Abuela
through the desert for one week
with nothing more than a few gallons of water,
and a prayer tucked into their pockets,
hoping both will last them long enough.

The sun is an unforgiving God, but any God
is worth having right now.

The wind pushing at their backs
is the grunt of gunshots from drug cartels
and the desperation of a job to employ their stomachs.
Both have been uninvited guests at their doorstep.

so they step, step,
Ana Maria's small hand clutches the bottom
of her Abuela's dress,
another step,
her mother waits for her on the other side
hoping that her face still sings of home like it used to.
another step,
She is too young to know what "border" means,
she thinks that people
are just family members who haven't met yet.

After they arrive,
she will learn there are
some borders you can't cross by foot.

Ana Maria is now 10 years old.
She's learned enough English to translate for her parents,
but says that her thick accent is still a problem
she tries to fix by leaving it in her locker.
When her teacher calls on her to read
she tries to speak proper. Like proper has a sound.

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She pushes her tongue down so it doesn't roll her "r's,"
but she trips on the flatness of the syllables
that usually bounce with too much salsa.
She tries to rattle out the kinks in her speech,
but her tongue is a stubborn dancer.

The two boys behind her don't know how to do long
division,
but they know what a wetback is,
and that Ana Maria has braids,
and that Ana Maria's hair is thicker than their sister's,
and they don't know how they know,
but they know how to treat difference when they smell it.
So they say things like, "Go back to your country,"
as if their Irish ancestors never walked through Ellis Island.

Ana Maria is now 16.
Her father works 18-hour days as a dishwasher.
Her mother cleans houses she'll never get to live in
so that Ana Maria can sit in a college classroom
and say, "I am here."

But her guidance counselor says she can't get financial aid,
or the in-state tuition rate, because of her status.
She says it like an apology.

Ana wonders if her family ever crossed the border,
or if they are just stuck inside another one,
aggravating it like a sore.

Her guidance counselor stands in front of her,
with a mouth full of fences.
There are some borders you can't cross by foot.
Borders, I tell her,
that can only be crossed by stubborn backbones

so if they ask you for your papers, show them your skin,
wear your tongue like a cape,
throw up your fist, like a secret you can't keep any longer,
they can't keep you any longer,
afraid you can't ever afford to drive or dream.

So if they come for you, tell them
in the language you know best,
that you are not scared anymore.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Denice Frohman
Book: Alight: Best-Loved Poems from the 2013 Women of the World Poetry Slam (Pg 86-89)
On-Line Location:
https://paperzz.com/doc/9383676/alight--the-poems-of-wowps-2013
ASIN: B00EHA5AYU
Publisher: Bicycle Comics
Date (Month/Year): 2013

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier – This poem only

****Introduction Source Information***

Reflections on the Global Refugee Forum and the Road Ahead in 2024 – January 3, 2024.
https://refugees.org/reflections-on-the-global-refugee-forum-and-the-road-ahead-in-2024/

****Transition Source Information***

What happens once asylum seekers arrive in the U.S.? – June 5, 2024
https://www.rescue.org/article/what-happens-once-asylum-seekers-arrive-us

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